Mike McKeown

Operating Partner and Independent Director · Technology and AI due diligence · Value creation and governance

Cotswolds, UK · +44 7785 362 573 · mike.mckeown@human-ai-systems.com · linkedin.com/in/mikesmckeown
Operating partner profile: human-ai-systems.com/ned-mike/operating-partner

PROFILE

Technology executive who came through the internet revolution and now works at the centre of the AI one. At Cisco I worked on the due diligence and integration of two multi-billion-pound acquisitions, then helped carve Synamedia out of Cisco under Permira's ownership. More recently I led enterprise AI transformation at an EU-listed cybersecurity company, with a framework approved by its board. I help investors judge a target's technology, data and AI position before they buy, and help portfolio companies turn technology into value afterwards. Most boards are well stocked with finance and legal expertise and short of people who understand technology. That is the gap I fill, as an operating partner on deals and as an independent director after acquisition.

WHAT I OFFER INVESTORS

- **Target screening and technology due diligence.** Product, architecture and engineering capability; cyber and data risk; scalability and technical debt; and the strength of the technology and commercial teams.
- **AI exposure and opportunity.** Whether AI threatens a target's business model or can lift its margins, and how credible management's AI plans are.
- **Separation, integration and the first 100 days.** Carving a business out of a parent's systems, integrating acquired teams, CRM and lead-to-cash, and operating model changes, including offshoring.
- **Value creation through digital and AI.** Practical AI adoption measured in win rates, productivity and cost to serve, with governance a board can sign off.
- **Independent director after acquisition.** Governance ready for growth, exit or a long hold; CEO succession and organisation design; oversight of technology, cyber and AI risk.

SELECTED DEALS

- **NDS acquisition, Cisco.** Member of the small pre-acquisition team, under NDA, for the purchase of the UK and Israel-based pay-TV technology company; then led the integration of the combined business development and presales organisations.
- **Tandberg acquisition, Cisco.** Contributed to the integration of the Norwegian video communications company into Cisco's collaboration business.
- **Synamedia carve-out to Permira.** Part of the team that handled the sale of Cisco's service provider video business, creating an independent company of 3,500 people. Led sales and service operations through the separation and built the new company's sales operations, CRM and board-level reporting.
- **Venture fundraising, Gravitas Tech and Solutions.** Advise the founders on investor readiness, valuation and dilution, SAFEs versus priced equity, and an investor-grade financial model.

CAREER

Founder and Managing Director, Human-AI Systems — Mar 2026 – present

- AI transformation consultancy: advises organisations on AI strategy and governance, builds practical AI systems, and trains teams. Co-created the From Prompt to Autopilot programme with John Clifton.

Advisory Board Member, Gravitas Tech and Solutions, a US AI start-up — Apr 2026 – present

- Advise the founders on strategy and fundraising, and challenge the assumptions on capital efficiency, linking each funding step to product, user-growth and commercial milestones.

Senior Director, AI Transformation and Sales Enablement, Verimatrix (EU-listed cybersecurity) — Sep 2022 – Mar 2026

- Appointed by the CEO to lead AI transformation across a nine-country business. Wrote the Responsible AI framework (EU AI Act, GDPR, DORA), took it to the board for approval and led the steering group that reported to the executive committee.
- Measured in business terms: around 10% better win rates in the SaaS business, about an hour a day back for every engineer, and around 30% fewer routine support tickets. Scaled the partner programme to more than 120 partners.

Senior Director, Sales Enablement and SDR, Kaltura — Jan 2022 – Sep 2022

- Built the company's first global sales enablement function across its media and telecoms markets.

Founder and Managing Director, Somerford Tech, my own consultancy — Jul 2020 – Jan 2022

- Advised technology companies on go-to-market, business development and digital transformation, including a £100K+ video platform win with a European broadcaster for Spicy Mango Technology.

Adviser and Shareholder, GSM, an innovation and venture development company — 2021 – 2024

- Advised founders and venture teams on commercial strategy, funding and market entry in health technology, IoT and supply-chain ventures.

Senior Director, Business Development and Operations, Synamedia — 2018 – 2020

- Business lead for the new company's own CRM, moving off Cisco's systems early and saving millions in charges. Led the move of a substantial part of engineering and support to India: a difficult change for the people affected, which cut annual costs by millions while keeping service to customers running.

Senior leadership roles, Cisco — 1994 – 2018

- Led the EMEA education and local government business, over £300M a year, growing it by 20% and lifting win rates in key segments from around 40% to 60%.
- Senior Director of Business Development for the video business across EMEA, Asia Pacific and China, leading a team of twelve. Sales Director for the BT Group relationship. Selected for the Cisco Accelerated Development Programme.

Earlier: EMEA presales and product management, Network Systems Corporation (1990 – 1994); project manager and network architect, GCHQ (1986 – 1990).

BOARD AND GOVERNANCE

- **Trustee and Non-Executive Director, Gloucestershire Rural Community Council (since Mar 2026).** Strategy, financial sustainability and governance; strengthened the business case for a major digital platform investment.
- **Cabinet Member for Digital and Climate, Cotswold District Council (since May 2023).** Chair the AI Oversight Board (Chief Executive, Chief Finance Officer, Chief Information Officer and Leader of the Council) and the Climate Change Board.
- **Co-Founder and Director, Thames Head Community Energy (since Jan 2022).** A community benefit society with a board of seven directors, developing community-owned solar.

ENGAGEMENT AND CONFLICTS

- **How I work:** a retained operating partner, a few hours a week or by the deal, with the option of an independent director seat on companies the firm acquires. Based in the Cotswolds; happy to travel.
- **Conflicts:** I declare my interests at every board and never sell my consultancy's services to a board I sit on. As an elected councillor, I do not take roles where the organisation's business comes before my council.

EDUCATION AND DEVELOPMENT

BSc (Hons) Computer Science, Economics and Psychology, Swansea University · Mini-MBA, INSEAD · UK100 Climate Leadership Academy (one of 20 councillors selected nationally)